

NEW BEDFELLOWS

A realignment of forces is likely to emerge before the next polls as the DMK ejects PMK from the ruling DPA front, a move that may send Ramadoss' party into the arms of Jayalalithaa's AIADMK



■ **By Lakshmi Subramanian**

It's like a marriage that ends in divorce but the partners agree to continue to cohabit. On June 17, the six-year-old alliance between the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) reached a flashpoint as Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi unilat-

PAST TIMES: Ramadoss (left) and Karunanidhi in better days

erally snapped ties with the PMK. Relations between the two parties, which are alliance partners at the Centre and in Chennai, had been on a boil in recent months.

"We cannot continue with this alliance as it would mean remaining

with those who humiliate us," said Karunanidhi. Asked if he would reconsider his decision if PMK founder S. Ramadoss approached him on a "forget and forgive" basis, Karunanidhi shot back, "It is for us to forget and forgive. Not them."

The ouster of the PMK from the DMK-led Democratic Progressive Alliance (DPA) in Tamil Nadu does not affect the ruling combine in Chennai or the UPA at the Centre. The minority DMK still commands the numbers, thanks to support from the Congress, the two communist parties and smaller outfits. The DMK patriarch has rather been magnanimous in not insisting on the PMK's ouster from the UPA in Delhi, which would have effectively ended the tenure of Anbumani Ramadoss, son of S. Ramadoss, as the Union Health Minister. Karunanidhi, in fact, was more harsh on his grand nephew Dayanidhi Maran, whose recall from the Union Cabinet he insisted upon as soon as the family feud broke out over a year ago.

The arrangement is only the latest example of the political engineering that the UPA is experimenting with, where foes at the local level sup with each other at the Centre. Lalu Prasad Yadav and Ram Vilas Paswan—who publicly fight over Bihar—dine together at UPA gatherings in Delhi. The communists—who fight no-holds-barred battles in Kerala and West Bengal with the Congress—prop the party at the Centre.

Though it took a long time coming, the parting of ways was along expected lines. Ever since the DMK Government was formed in May 2006, the PMK had been acting more like an opposition party than an alliance partner. Ramadoss opposed many of Karunanidhi's initiatives such as setting up of SEZs, satellite towns, airport expansion, education and retail-related issues and price hike,